

Social and Cultural Diversity Analysis

Kolby J. Ray

College of Humanities and Social Sciences, Grand Canyon University

CNL-509-O500, Counseling the Culturally Diverse

Dr. Zandra Rutledge

December 3, 2024

Social and Cultural Diversity Analysis

Social and cultural diversity is a very important aspect of effective and ethical counseling practice, which requires an ongoing search for knowledge and understanding, respecting, and integrating the unique identities and experiences of culturally diverse clients. Reflecting on one's own personal experience and history with discrimination as well as personal biases fosters greater self-awareness, a vital characteristic for culturally competent counselors. Personal experiences with discrimination provide a lens through which counselors can empathize with their clients' struggles, while also recognizing the existence of systemic forces that bring about inequality. This paper will analyze my own personal experiences with discrimination, lived or observed, as well as my reflections of racism and discrimination. This paper will also identify and explain certain codes listed in the ACA Code of Ethics regarding culturally competent counseling.

Part One: Personal History with Discrimination

1. Personal Biases and Their Impact on my Counseling Approach

Mental health providers are frequently trained in cultural competence to better serve a growingly diverse client base. However, despite this preparation, many still find it challenging to effectively engage with multicultural populations (Desai et al., 2021). I was originally unaware of having any personal bias towards a certain demographic of people until I took two implicit bias tests regarding both religion and race. Although implicit and unconscious, the results revealed that I do have personal bias towards certain demographics of people. My job as a counselor is to create an environment of acceptance, where my clients feel safe and able to share their most personal struggles.

2. Personal History with Discrimination

My personal experience with discrimination is brief and not nearly as impactful as it has been for minority populations. The only time I felt discriminated against was in my Psychology of Gender class during my undergraduate work. As a class we often engaged in group discussion where we shared our personal thoughts and feelings about difficult topics regarding race, gender, and sexuality. During one session of class, we talked about the BLM movement and whether we thought it was a good or bad thing. I stated that I felt that the BLM movement, although held good intentions, did more harm than good. I also believe that it added to the negative stereotypes and biases towards people of color. After making my statement, about half the class ganged up on me and they claimed that I will never understand what it's like to be black, and that I am a racist, misogynistic, white supremacist male that doesn't have the right to speak on matters that I don't understand. While I don't know what it's like to be discriminated against on a major level because of the color of my skin, I do feel that I have a right to my opinion just as everyone else does. Significant and persistent racial and ethnic disparities in mental and physical health are well-documented in the United States. A 2004 report highlighted substantial differences in disease prevalence and mortality rates among African Americans, Latinos, and Whites (Sawyer et al., 2012).

3. Memories of Contact with Individuals of Different Cultures

Multicultural groups are diverse not only in their beliefs and expectations, but also in their assumptions about how the world works and should be viewed (Alegria et al., 2011). From 2017-2019, I served an LDS mission in the country of Armenia. Their beliefs and worldviews were drastically different than my own. However, instead of trying to remain in my own culture, I embraced theirs. I talked like them, ate like them, and what they valued as important, I found myself valuing the same. The belief in being hospitable towards everyone, including strangers. I

would get invited into the homes of random people daily to have food or a drink of some sort. That is something that we will never see in America, but it's something I cherish deeply about the Armenian people.

4. Life Experience and Relating with Others

I grew up believing that we should treat others the way we want to be treated. A major contributing factor to that belief stemmed from my religious beliefs, to treat others with kindness because we are all sons and daughters of God. Different cultures were never something that I avoided, in fact, I embraced it the best that I could. As counselors, we don't have to embrace or agree with every client's value or belief, but we can do our part to understand and respect it.

Part Two: Reflections of Racism/Discrimination

1. What Does it Mean to be a Subtle Racist?

A subtle racist engages in discriminatory attitudes and behaviors in indirect, covert, or less overtly offensive ways compared to overt racism (Liao et al., 2016). These discriminatory attitudes and behaviors include microaggressions, stereotyping, and implicit biases. Recognizing modern forms of racism, particularly subtle racism, poses challenges because it is often difficult to detect, and the behaviors involved can be readily attributed to other factors (Liao et al., 2016). However, it's important to keep in mind that holding implicit or unconscious biases doesn't mean that you are a subtle racist.

2. Why Could There be Significant Differences in Perceptions and Values of Members

Within the Same Ethnic Group?

Group membership significantly influences how we interpret and assign meaning to the actions of others. Likewise, our perceptions of racism are often shaped by the groups to which we belong (Carter & Murphy, 2015). I think there are a few reasons that there may be significant

differences in perceptions of values of members within the same ethnic group, mainly demographical differences such as socioeconomic status and geographic location. Members of the same ethnic group living in different countries or regions may experience differences in societal norms, laws, and cultural influences (Carter & Murphy, 2015).

Part Three: Applying Ethics and Cultural Identity

1. ACA Multicultural Codes

The ACA Code of Ethics encourages counselors to not only attempt to understand their client's cultural values, but also to explore their own cultural identity (Introduction ACA, 2014). In section A.2.C, the ACA claims that a counselor should develop cultural sensitivity which includes appropriate language and intervention strategies (ACA, 2014). In the introduction of section B, the ACA states that a counselor should also communicate the limits of confidentiality in a culturally appropriate manner (ACA, 2014). Finally, in section E.5.b, the ACA encourages counselors to be aware of the impact that culture has on how clients respond to certain experiences. In addition, a counselor should consider their client's socioeconomic status and cultural experiences when diagnosing mental disorders (ACA, 2014). My own cultural identity limits my knowledge of this field, in response to this issue I will need to make these codes a part of my counseling practice.

2. Applying Ethical Codes in Treatment Planning

The best way to apply ethical code considerations in treatment planning is by first getting to know your client. We can't help them until we understand how their culture and cultural experiences have shaped their understanding of mental health. Section A.11.a in the Code of Ethics states that a counselor should be knowledgeable of culturally appropriate referral resources (ACA, 2014).

3. Evidence-Based Strategies

Building rapport with diverse clients involves evidence-based strategies that foster trust and create a safe, inclusive environment. One evidence-based strategy is that of empathetic questioning/listening. Let's discuss the cultural identities of religion and socioeconomic status. Actively listen using SOLER skills when clients discuss their spiritual beliefs, rituals, or struggles, and validate their importance. This shows respect for their worldview and lets them know that you are curious about their culture. When discussing socioeconomic status, acknowledge the challenges they may be facing without minimizing them. For example, if a client discusses financial stress, respond with empathy and support.

4. Resources to Dispel Personal Biases

There are multiple resources that counselors can use to help them dispel their biases and become more culturally sensitive counselors. One resource is the use of Implicit Association Tests. These tests help identify biases related to race, gender, religion, and other cultural identities. One other resource is scholarly articles or journals, studying these articles will help a counselor become more culturally competent. Some of these journals include Implicit Organizational Bias: Mental Health Treatment Culture and Norms as Barriers to Engaging with Diversity (Desai et al., 2021), Discrimination and the Stress Response: Psychological and Physiological Consequences of Anticipating Prejudice in Interethnic Interactions (Sawyer et al., 2012), Clinicians' Cognitive and Affective Biases and the Practice of Psychotherapy (Yager et al., 2021), and The Case for Cultural Competency in Psychotherapeutic Interventions (Sue et al., 2009).

5. Multicultural Competence

Multicultural competence is the ability to engage and communicate with individuals from diverse backgrounds and cultures, using culturally appropriate language. In addition, the ability a counselor must plan treatment that aligns with the client's cultural values and worldviews. The discussions we have had during this course have inspired me to continuously seek knowledge of the various cultures I may encounter as a professional. I have also had my heart softened for those from different cultures that I do not fully understand. I will continue to rid myself of biases, unconscious or otherwise, to be the most accepting and culturally appropriate counselor I can be.

Conclusion

Understanding and addressing social and cultural diversity is essential for creating an ethical and effective counseling practice. Through self-reflection on personal experiences with discrimination and awareness of systemic inequalities, counselors can develop greater empathy and cultural competence. This self-awareness, paired with adherence to ethical guidelines such as those outlined in the ACA Code of Ethics, helps counselors respect and integrate the cultural identities and experiences of their clients. By continually striving to expand their knowledge and challenge personal biases, counselors can create inclusive spaces that promote healing and empowerment for diverse populations.

References

- 2014 ACA Code of ethics. (n.d.). <https://www.counseling.org/docs/default-source/ethics/2014-aca-code-of-ethics.pdf>
- Alegria, M., Atkins, M., Farmer, E., Slaton, E., & Stelk, W. (2010). One size does not fit all: Taking diversity, culture and context seriously. *Administration and Policy in Mental Health and Mental Health Services Research*, 37(1–2), 48–60.
<https://doi.org/10.1007/s10488-010-0283-2>
- Carter, E. R., & Murphy, M. C. (2015). Group-based differences in perceptions of racism: What counts, to whom, and why? *Social and Personality Psychology Compass*, 9(6), 269–280.
<https://doi.org/10.1111/spc3.12181>
- Desai, M. U., Paranamana, N., Restrepo-Toro, M., O’Connell, M., Davidson, L., & Stanhope, V. (2021). Implicit organizational bias: Mental health treatment culture and norms as barriers to engaging with diversity. *American Psychologist*, 76(1), 78–90.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/amp0000621>
- Liao, H.-Y., Hong, Y., & Rounds, J. (2016). Perception of subtle racism. *The Counseling Psychologist*, 44(2), 237–266. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0011000015625329>
- Sawyer, P. J., Major, B., Casad, B. J., Townsend, S. S. M., & Mendes, W. B. (2012). Discrimination and the stress response: Psychological and physiological consequences of anticipating prejudice in interethnic interactions. *American Journal of Public Health*, 102(5), 1020–1026. <https://doi.org/10.2105/ajph.2011.300620>
- Sue, S., Zane, N., Nagayama Hall, G. C., & Berger, L. K. (2009). The case for cultural competency in psychotherapeutic interventions. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 60(1), 525–548. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.60.110707.163651>

Yager, J., Kay, J., & Kelsay, K. (2021). Clinicians' cognitive and affective biases and the practice of psychotherapy. *American Journal of Psychotherapy*, 74(3), 119–126.

<https://doi.org/10.1176/appi.psychotherapy.20200025>